

Overview of Online Travel Planning

Travel planning shifted from physical agencies to online platforms following the rise of online travel agencies (OTAs) in 1996, beginning with the individual booking platform Booking.com [1]. OTAs aggregate flights, hotels and experiences in one place, use algorithms to personalise recommendations and allow easy comparison of options.

Early online marketing offered customers price transparency through easy comparison across currencies and channels [2]. However, recent research [3] shows customers now face hidden fees, manipulated reviews and fraudulent listings, making trustworthiness and price transparency problems platforms must be solved.

Despite these issues, the global online travel market is projected to grow from US\$540 billion in 2024 to nearly US\$1.95 trillion in 2033 driven by AI, peer reviews, digital marketing, heightened reach, improved customer market position and ease of engagement [4][5][1].

Types of Travel Products and Agencies

- ❖ Online travel agencies already available
 - Expedia.com
 - Travelocity.com
 - Tripadvisor.com
 - Booking.com
- ❖ Packaged based platforms compared to individual booking platforms
 - Package-based platforms aggregate multiple travel components such as flights, accommodation, activities and more in one place using relationships with suppliers to gain bulk rates, offering customised itineraries and support for complex trips, offering all inclusive convenience, group discounts and expert handling of logistics such as visas
 - <https://www.itilite.com/blog/best-online-travel-agency/>
 - Individual booking platforms like expedia.com or booking.com focus on speed, control and price comparison for simple or standalone reservations
 - <https://www.reslogic.com/blog/travel-agency-tour-operator>
 - Individual booking platforms allow users to search, compare and book single travel components, focusing on real-time price transparency, user reviews and algorithm-driven filters providing less support, but aiding users to find the lowest individual rates
 - Users are in charge of coordination and logistics and resolving disruptions
 - <https://www.reslogic.com/blog/travel-agency-tour-operator>
- ❖ Other niche agencies (look into specific interests)
 - Cater to specific travel segments, demographics or activities, providing curation that generalist platforms may miss
 - They may cater to eco-tourists, surfers, fishing enthusiasts, wine lovers or others, providing tailored services
 - Captain Experiences is an online travel agency specialising in fishing and outdoor adventures
 - Winerist is for wine tours
 - Thermal is for surf trips
 - KidPass is for kid-friendly activities
 - <https://mize.tech/blog/travel-niche-what-it-is-how-to-leverage-it-case-studies-more/>
- ❖ What travel packages consist of
 - They focus on providing curated convenience and bundled value for complex/luxury travel
 - <https://navan.com/blog/biggest-online-travel-agencies>

How Content is Rated and Categorised

- ❖ Star ratings, user reviews and verified reviews
 - Ratings aim to provide an objective assessment of quality and experience, however reviews can differ from ratings, whereby ratings do not match the customers' view of quality

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10256918/>
- Star ratings reflect features, whilst review scores tend to reflect that and more
 - <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10256918/>
- Verified ratings and reviews ensure transparency due to potential falsified reviews and ratings, ensuring that the reviews and ratings come from another user and are not spam or from the company, making transparency an additional challenge in this regard [3]
- ❖ How platforms categorise destinations and attractions
 - Packages and options are typically categorised by destination such as cities, countries or regions
 - This allows a global traveler pool
 - <https://www.xola.com/articles/how-do-otas-work/>
 - Other categories include activity specialisation or niche, including platforms which exclusively focus on specific categories such as BringFido offering pet-friendly accommodations
 - <https://www.xola.com/articles/how-do-otas-work/>
 - Categories assist users in finding relevant experiences
 - <https://www.xola.com/articles/how-do-otas-work/>
- ❖ Price tiers, destination tags and activity categories
 - Content can further be organised based on price ranges, such as Expedia which allows users to filter and sort by price (among other filters and sorts)
 - Destination tags and activity categories
 - Based on platform observation of expedia.com
- ❖ Trust mechanisms such as agency verification and review moderation
 - Ambiguous policies, fraudulent listings, wasted time, base prices being low necessitate trust mechanisms [3]

Additional Features

- ❖ Recommendation engines (browsing history, budget, preferences)
 - Extreme personalisation through advanced algorithms [3]
 - AI integration for streamlined customer experience [5]
 - Dynamic pricing, quicker customer service through chatbots [5]
 - Mobile-based engagement further increases accessibility [5]
- ❖ Group travel coordination (how platforms handle group bookings)
 - Primarily through the use of dedicated online portals where there are group quotes, manage deposits, passenger name lists and then the final manifest is confirmed and they can book in bulk and finalise itineraries
 - <https://monday.com/blog/crm-and-sales/travel-agent-crm/>
 - Shared booking links can be used allowing travellers to book under a group whilst retaining their own tracking
 - <https://www.altexsoft.com/blog/corporate-group-travel/>
 - Airlines can provide block bookings and provide dynamic pricing to ensure profitability and availability
 - <https://www.groupm.net/group-travel-booking/>
 - Manual updates can be done for larger groups or for specific requirements, necessitating dedicated support teams
 - <https://www.travelomatix.com/software/how-do-travel-agencies-manage-group-bookings>
 - Making use of views within the logistical system to consolidate data and have custom reports to navigate logistics
 - <https://www.altexsoft.com/blog/corporate-group-travel/>
- ❖ User review systems and their impact on agency reputation
 - Peer reviews and online content encouraging people to gain unique experiences, particularly amongst gen z and millennials [5]
- ❖ Price comparison tools and how they aggregate data across agencies
 - Make use of web scraping, global distribution systems and API integrations to aggregate real-time pricing data from multiple sources and competitor platforms
 - <https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/air-fare-compare-web-scraping/>

- Meta search engines such as skyscanner or kayak can consolidate rates from various sources, helping OTAs analyse pricing and different promotions
 - <https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/top-travel-data-sources-to-scrape/>
 - <https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/evolving-relation-between-otas-metasearch-engines/>
- The data is then structured and analysed to present a view of options in one interface
 - <https://www.mightytravels.com/2024/09/the-hidden-algorithms-how-third-party-travel-sites-secure-lower-flight-prices/>
- Travel price intelligence systems leveraging AI-driven algorithms and machine learning process the aggregated data and they then enable dynamic prices
 - <https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/air-fare-compare-web-scraping/>

Sources

[1]

“How Online Travel Agencies Transformed the Industry,” *Itb.com*, Jan. 09, 2026.

<https://www.itb.com/en/itb-360%C2%B0/news-insights/a-milestone-for-booking-convenience-how-online-travel-agencies-transformed-the-industry.html> (accessed May 19, 2026).

[2]

R. Egger and I. Walters, “Price Transparency on the Internet Requirements of Revenue Management for the Development of an Online Strategy in the Hospitality Industry,” *Palgrave Macmillan UK eBooks*, pp. 159–171, Jan. 2008, doi:

https://doi.org/10.1057/9780230594890_7.

[3]

E. Theto, J. Roberson, and A. Smith, “Perceptions of Trust and Purchase Decisions in Tourism E-Commerce Platforms Abstract Corresponding Author,” *African Journal of Hospitality, Tourism and Leisure*, vol. 14, no. 2, pp. 309–316, 2025, doi: <https://doi.org/10.46222/ajhtl.19770720.611>.

[4]

SkyQuest Technology Consulting, “Online Travel Market Size, Share, Trends & Forecast | 2031,” Dec. 2025. Accessed: May 19, 2026. [Online]. Available: <https://www.skyquestt.com/report/online-travel-market>

[5]

Growth Market Reports, “Growth Market Reports,” *Growthmarketreports.com*, 2024.

<https://growthmarketreports.com/report/online-travel-market-global-industry-analysis> (accessed May 19, 2026).

[6]

Y. Verma, “Travel Management Software,” *ITILITE: Unified Corporate Travel and Expense Management*, Sep. 06, 2023. <https://www.italite.com/blog/best-online-travel-agency/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[7]

reslogic, “Travel Agencies vs. Tour Operators: Online Booking Impact,” *Reslogic.com*, Dec. 23, 2024.

<https://www.reslogic.com/blog/travel-agency-tour-operator> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[8]

M. Truyols, “Travel Niche: What It Is, How to Leverage It, Case Studies & More,” *Mize*, Mar. 07, 2024.

<https://mize.tech/blog/travel-niche-what-it-is-how-to-leverage-it-case-studies-more/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[9]

P. Colón, “How the Biggest Online Travel Agencies are Driving Business Travel in 2025,” *Navan*, Mar. 31, 2025.

<https://navan.com/blog/biggest-online-travel-agencies> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[10]

M. Arzaghi, I. H. Genc, and S. Naik, “Rating vs. Reviews: Does official rating capture what is important to customers?,” *Heliyon*, vol. 9, no. 5, pp. e16337–e16337, May 2023, doi: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2023.e16337>.

[11]

C. Vianna, “How do Online Travel Agencies Work,” *Xola*, May 04, 2022.

<https://www.xola.com/articles/how-do-otas-work/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[12]

monday.com, “Travel agent CRM: 5 platforms that actually handle group bookings (2026),” *monday.com Blog*, Apr. 14, 2026. <https://monday.com/blog/crm-and-sales/travel-agent-crm/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[13]

O. Pereverzieva, “Corporate Group Travel: Why Flying 20 Colleagues to One Event Is a Mess,” *AltexSoft*, Mar. 25, 2026. <https://www.altexsoft.com/blog/corporate-group-travel/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[14]

Sivasankaran, “What Is Group Booking in Flights? The Ultimate Guide,” *GroupRM*, Dec. 18, 2024.

<https://www.grouprm.net/group-travel-booking/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[15]

Travelomatix, “How do travel agencies manage group bookings?,” *Travelomatix*, 2017.

<https://www.travelomatix.com/software/how-do-travel-agencies-manage-group-bookings> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[16]

Jimna Jayan, “How Air Fare Compare Helps OTAs and Airlines Stay Competitive?,” *PromptCloud*, Dec. 26, 2024.

<https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/air-fare-compare-web-scraping/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[17]

Jimna Jayan, “Top Sources for Travel Data Scraping: Insights for Market Leaders,” *PromptCloud*, Jan. 15, 2025.

<https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/top-travel-data-sources-to-scrape/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[18]

Administrator, “Meta Search Engine and Online Travel Agencies - A Detailed Look,” *PromptCloud*, Mar. 15, 2017.

<https://www.promptcloud.com/blog/evolving-relation-between-otas-metasearch-engines/> (accessed May 20, 2026).

[19]

Mighty Travels Premium, “The Hidden Algorithms How Third-Party Travel Sites Secure Lower Flight Prices,” *Mighty Travels Premium*, Sep. 2024.

<https://www.mightytravels.com/2024/09/the-hidden-algorithms-how-third-party-travel-sites-secure-lower-flight-prices/>
(accessed May 20, 2026).

[20]
Expedia, “Expedia Travel: Search Hotels, Cheap Flights, Car Rentals & Vacations,” *Expedia.com*, 2020.
<https://expedia.com> (accessed May 20, 2026).